A Finite Schur–Feshbach Test for Reflected Wilson Blocks: An Explicit Four-Dimensional $SU(2)$ Heat-Kernel Lattice Realization

Andre Freitas

Affiliation and contact information to be supplied

July 10, 2026

Abstract

We give a fully specified finite-cutoff realization of a Schur–Feshbach positivity test for reflected Wilson observables. The matrix statement is the rank-one specialization of standard second-order geometry of the positive-semidefinite cone: if

$$q_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^* + \varepsilon H + \varepsilon^2 K + o(\varepsilon^2),$$

then, after eliminating the rank-one direction, the first two coefficients are

$$A = PHP, \qquad C = P\big(K - n^{-1} H e e^* H\big)P, \qquad e = n^{-1/2}\mathbf{1}, \quad P = I - ee^*.$$

The field-theoretic contribution is an explicit same-theory block. On a finite four-dimensional reflection-symmetric lattice with gauge group $SU(2)$ and heat-kernel plaquette weight, we define three closed hairpin loops sharing a base path. A spatial-reflection odd Wilson mode X and an even centered Wilson mode Y generate three positive-time observables

$$F_i^\varepsilon = 1 + \sqrt{\varepsilon}\, b_i X + \varepsilon c_i Y, \qquad b = (1,-1,0)^T, \quad c = (0,0,1)^T.$$

Their reflected Gram matrix is exactly

$$N_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^T + \varepsilon\sigma b b^T + \varepsilon^2 \tau c c^T, \qquad \sigma = \langle \Theta X, X\rangle_{\mathrm{OS}} \geq 0, \quad \tau = \langle \Theta Y, Y\rangle_{\mathrm{OS}} \geq 0.$$

Diagonal correlation normalization is realized by rescaling the same observables, hence is an exact congruence rather than an uncontrolled entrywise quotient. The normalized block has a rank-one limit and yields

$$PHP = \sigma b b^T, \qquad C = -\sigma^2 b b^T + \frac{\tau}{9} z z^T, \qquad z = (1,1,-2)^T.$$

Thus the first reduced eigenvalue is 2σ, while the corrected second-order null-sector eigenvalue is $2\tau/3$. The uncorrected quantity contains a spurious σ^2 term, which the Schur–Feshbach correction removes. All statements up to this point are exact at finite cutoff. Geometric collar collapse, uniform nondegeneracy along a continuum trajectory, endpoint cumulant estimates, infinite volume, and a spectral-gap implication are isolated as explicit open modules rather than claimed results.

Contents

1 Scope, novelty, and claim boundary **2**

2 Finite reflected Gram matrices and the Schur–Feshbach test **3**

3 A reflection-positive four-dimensional lattice model **4**
3.1 Finite lattice, action, and reflections 4
3.2 Three explicit closed hairpins 5

4 The exact three-hairpin source block **6**
4.1 Positive-time observables and exact Gram matrix 6
4.2 Same-theory correlation normalization 7

5 Coefficient extraction and the finite certificate **8**

6 Finite evaluation and reproducibility protocol **10**

7 Open modules toward a geometric collar and a mass-gap programme **10**
7.1 Cutoff trajectory and geometric collision 10
7.2 Correct endpoint/null-channel bookkeeping 13
7.3 From OS positivity to a spectral gap 14

8 Conclusion **15**

A Normalization algebra **16**

B Exact block algebra and uniform remainder **16**

C Five-point fourth-derivative certificate **17**

D Checklist for the next manuscript revision **18**

1 Scope, novelty, and claim boundary

The Yang–Mills existence and mass-gap problem asks for a nontrivial four-dimensional quantum Yang–Mills theory for every compact simple gauge group and a positive mass gap in the same reconstructed theory [10, 11]. Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction provides a Euclidean route, in which reflection positivity is one indispensable axiom [2, 3]. At finite lattice spacing, standard plaquette gauge actions furnish reflection-positive regulated theories [6, 5].

This paper makes a deliberately narrower contribution. It does not construct a continuum Yang–Mills measure, establish all OS axioms, prove exponential clustering, or prove a mass gap. It does two finite things:

(i) it states the rank-one Schur–Feshbach coefficient test for a singular PSD matrix family; and

(ii) it implements that test on an explicit four-dimensional $SU(2)$ lattice Wilson block whose action, reflection, observables, normalization, rank-one limit, coefficients, and finite margins are all specified.

The Schur-complement curvature term is not presented as a new discovery in matrix analysis. It is a rank-one instance of the established second-order geometry of semidefinite constraints [8, 9]. The purpose of retaining the finite theorem is to make the Wilson calculation self-contained and to show exactly where the curvature correction enters. The substantive advance over a purely schematic Wilson/OS discussion is the same-theory realization in Sections 3–5.

Claim boundary. All results through Corollary 5.4 hold on a fixed finite lattice, and the source-collision expansion is uniform over arbitrary cutoff families because the primitive Wilson observables are bounded. Strict positive margins require the finite nondegeneracy conditions $\sigma > 0$ and $\tau > 0$. No uniform lower bound on these quantities as the cutoff is removed is proved here.

2 Finite reflected Gram matrices and the Schur–Feshbach test

Let Θ be an antilinear Euclidean reflection and let $\mathcal{A}_+$ be an algebra of positive-time observables. Reflection positivity means

$$\sum_{i,j=1}^{n} \overline{c_i} c_j \, \langle (\Theta F_i)^* F_j \rangle \geq 0 \tag{1}$$

for every finite family $F_1, \ldots, F_n \in \mathcal{A}_+$ and every $c \in \mathbb{C}^n$. Equivalently, the reflected Gram matrix

$$N_{ij} = \langle (\Theta F_i)^* F_j \rangle \tag{2}$$

is positive semidefinite.

Suppose a normalized finite block has a rank-one collision expansion

$$q_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^* + \varepsilon H + \varepsilon^2 K + R_\varepsilon, \qquad \|R_\varepsilon\| = o(\varepsilon^2), \tag{3}$$

where $H, K \in \mathrm{Herm}_n(\mathbb{C})$. Define

$$e = n^{-1/2}\mathbf{1}, \qquad P = I - ee^*. \tag{4}$$

Then P projects onto $\mathbf{1}^\perp$ and $\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^* = nee^*$.

Theorem 2.1 (Rank-one Schur–Feshbach certificate)**.** *Let q_ε satisfy (3). Set*

$$\lambda_\varepsilon = e^* q_\varepsilon e, \qquad \mathcal{F}_\varepsilon = P q_\varepsilon P - P q_\varepsilon e \, \lambda_\varepsilon^{-1} e^* q_\varepsilon P. \tag{5}$$

For all sufficiently small $\varepsilon > 0$, $\lambda_\varepsilon > 0$ and

$$q_\varepsilon \succeq 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \mathcal{F}_\varepsilon \succeq 0. \tag{6}$$

Moreover,

$$\mathcal{F}_\varepsilon = \varepsilon A + \varepsilon^2 C + o(\varepsilon^2), \qquad A = PHP, \qquad C = P\big(K - n^{-1} H e e^* H\big)P. \tag{7}$$

If $q_\varepsilon \succeq 0$ for all sufficiently small $\varepsilon > 0$, then

$$A \succeq 0 \quad \text{on } \mathbf{1}^\perp, \tag{8}$$

and, writing Π for the orthogonal projection onto $\operatorname{Ker} A \subset \mathbf{1}^\perp$,

$$\Pi C \Pi \succeq 0 \quad \text{on } \operatorname{Ker} A. \tag{9}$$

Proof. Since $q_0 = nee^*$,

$$\lambda_\varepsilon = n + \varepsilon e^* H e + O(\varepsilon^2) > 0$$

for small ε. With respect to $\mathbb{C}^n = \mathbb{C}e \oplus P\mathbb{C}^n$, the usual scalar Schur complement gives (6). Furthermore,

$$\begin{aligned} Pq_\varepsilon P &= \varepsilon PHP + \varepsilon^2 PKP + o(\varepsilon^2), \\ Pq_\varepsilon e &= \varepsilon PHe + \varepsilon^2 PKe + o(\varepsilon^2), \\ \lambda_\varepsilon^{-1} &= n^{-1} + O(\varepsilon). \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$Pq_\varepsilon e\, \lambda_\varepsilon^{-1} e^* q_\varepsilon P = \varepsilon^2 n^{-1} PHee^*HP + o(\varepsilon^2),$$

which proves (7). If $\mathcal{F}_\varepsilon \succeq 0$, then for $v \in \mathbf{1}^\perp$,

$$0 \le v^* \mathcal{F}_\varepsilon v = \varepsilon v^* A v + \varepsilon^2 v^* C v + o(\varepsilon^2).$$

Division first by ε, and then by ε^2 on $\operatorname{Ker} A$, gives (8) and (9). □

Remark 2.2 (The curvature correction)**.** *Since* $ee^* = n^{-1}\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^*$,

$$C = PKP - n^{-2} PH\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^* HP. \tag{10}$$

The second term is the excursion from $\mathbf{1}^\perp$ *into the rank-one direction and back. Replacing* C *by* PKP *generally changes the null-sector value.*

Proposition 2.3 (Strict second-order sufficiency)**.** *Assume* $A \succeq 0$ *on* $\mathbf{1}^\perp$*. Let* Π *project onto* $\operatorname{Ker} A$ *and put* $Q = P - \Pi$*. If, for some* $\alpha, \beta > 0$*,*

$$QAQ \succeq \alpha Q, \qquad \Pi C \Pi \succeq \beta \Pi, \tag{11}$$

then $q_\varepsilon \succeq 0$ *for all sufficiently small* $\varepsilon > 0$*.*

Proof. On $Q\mathbb{C}^n$, $Q\mathcal{F}_\varepsilon Q = \varepsilon QAQ + O(\varepsilon^2)$ is positive and has inverse of order $O(\varepsilon^{-1})$. Because $A\Pi = 0 = \Pi A$, the off-diagonal block $\Pi \mathcal{F}_\varepsilon Q$ is $O(\varepsilon^2)$. The Schur complement on $\Pi\mathbb{C}^n$ is therefore

$$\varepsilon^2 \Pi C \Pi + o(\varepsilon^2) - O(\varepsilon^3),$$

which is positive for small ε by (11). Theorem 2.1 then gives $q_\varepsilon \succeq 0$. □

Remark 2.4 (Higher-order recursion requires higher-order data)**.** *The two-order hypothesis* (3) *supports only the two tests above. A recursive null-sector procedure is justified only when an asymptotic expansion through the required order, or analyticity in* ε*, is available. An* $o(\varepsilon^2)$ *remainder alone does not determine the next sign.*

3 A reflection-positive four-dimensional lattice model

3.1 Finite lattice, action, and reflections

Fix a lattice spacing $a > 0$, integers $T, L \ge 1$, and the finite reflection-symmetric lattice

$$\Lambda_{T,L} = \{-T+1, \dots, T\} \times (\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z})^3. \tag{12}$$

The first coordinate is Euclidean time. An oriented nearest-neighbour edge ℓ carries a link variable $U_\ell \in SU(2)$, with $U_{\bar{\ell}} = U_\ell^{-1}$. For a plaquette p, U_p is the ordered product of link variables around its boundary.

Let K_κ be the $SU(2)$ heat kernel at time $\kappa > 0$, in the convention

$$K_\kappa(g) = \sum_{j \in \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{N}_0} (2j+1) e^{-\kappa j(j+1)} \chi_j(g). \tag{13}$$

The finite-volume heat-kernel plaquette measure is

$$d\mu_{\Lambda,\kappa}(U) = Z_{\Lambda,\kappa}^{-1} \left(\prod_\ell dU_\ell \right) \left(\prod_p K_\kappa(U_p) \right), \tag{14}$$

where dU_ℓ is normalized Haar measure. This is a finite-dimensional probability measure. The heat-kernel action is a standard lattice Yang–Mills action and has strictly positive character coefficients [7].

Reflect the lattice through the link plane $t = \frac{1}{2}$:

$$\vartheta(t, x_1, x_2, x_3) = (1 - t, x_1, x_2, x_3). \tag{15}$$

The induced antilinear operation on observables is denoted by Θ. Let $\mathcal{A}_+$ be the gauge-invariant Wilson algebra generated by loops whose links lie entirely in the positive half $t \geq 1$.

Proposition 3.1 (Finite reflection positivity)**.** *For the measure* (14)*,*

$$\langle (\Theta F)^* F \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa} \geq 0 \qquad (F \in \mathcal{A}_+). \tag{16}$$

Consequently every finite reflected Wilson Gram matrix is positive semidefinite.

Justification. This is the standard link-reflection positivity theorem for plaquette gauge actions with nonnegative character coefficients [6, 5]. In the heat-kernel case the coefficients in (13) are positive. The Peter–Weyl expansion factorizes each plaquette crossing the reflection plane into a sum of reflected products with nonnegative weights; plaquettes entirely on one side occur in reflected pairs. Expanding the finite product and integrating gives (16). □

We also use the spatial reflection

$$\rho(t, x_1, x_2, x_3) = (t, x_1, -x_2, x_3). \tag{17}$$

The measure is invariant under ρ, and ρ commutes with ϑ.

3.2 Three explicit closed hairpins

Let e_0, e_1, e_2, e_3 be the lattice unit vectors, with e_0 temporal. Choose positive integers r, s, h so that the following paths do not wrap around the finite box. Put

$$A = (1, 0, 0, 0), \qquad B = A + re_1,$$

and let β be the straight path from A to B. Define three detours from A to B:

$$\eta_+ : A \longrightarrow A + se_2 \longrightarrow B + se_2 \longrightarrow B, \tag{18}$$

$$\eta_- : A \longrightarrow A - se_2 \longrightarrow B - se_2 \longrightarrow B, \tag{19}$$

$$\eta_0 : A \longrightarrow A + he_0 \longrightarrow B + he_0 \longrightarrow B. \tag{20}$$

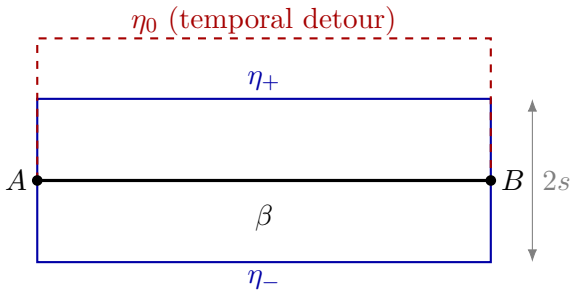


Figure 1: Schematic projection of the three detours. The dashed detour η_0 lies in the Euclidean-time direction; the picture only displays the shared-base incidence pattern.

The closed hairpin loops are

$$\gamma_\alpha = \eta_\alpha \circ \beta^{-1}, \qquad \alpha \in \{+, -, 0\}. \tag{21}$$

All links lie in $t \geq 1$. The loops share the base path β, and

$$\rho\gamma_+ = \gamma_-, \qquad \rho\gamma_0 = \gamma_0. \tag{22}$$

For a closed path γ, define the normalized fundamental Wilson loop

$$W_\gamma(U) = \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} U_\gamma. \tag{23}$$

For $SU(2)$ this is real and lies in $[-1, 1]$. Write $W_+ = W_{\gamma_+}$, $W_- = W_{\gamma_-}$, and $W_0 = W_{\gamma_0}$. Define

$$X = \frac{1}{2}(W_+ - W_-), \qquad Y = W_0 - m_0, \qquad m_0 = \langle W_0 \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa}. \tag{24}$$

Then $X, Y \in \mathcal{A}_+$, $|X| \leq 1$, $|Y| \leq 2$, and

$$\rho X = -X, \qquad \rho Y = Y, \qquad \langle X \rangle = \langle Y \rangle = 0. \tag{25}$$

Lemma 3.2 (Symmetry decoupling)**.** *The mixed reflected correlations vanish:*

$$\langle (\Theta X)Y \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa} = 0, \qquad \langle (\Theta Y)X \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa} = 0. \tag{26}$$

Proof. Because the measure is ρ-invariant and ρ commutes with Θ,

$$\langle (\Theta X)Y \rangle = \langle (\Theta\rho X)(\rho Y) \rangle = -\langle (\Theta X)Y \rangle.$$

Thus the first correlation is zero. The second is its Hermitian conjugate and also vanishes. □

4 The exact three-hairpin source block

4.1 Positive-time observables and exact Gram matrix

Let

$$b = (1, -1, 0)^T, \qquad c = (0, 0, 1)^T, \qquad z = (1, 1, -2)^T. \tag{27}$$

Thus $b \perp \mathbf{1}$, $z \perp \mathbf{1}$, and $b \perp z$. For $\varepsilon \geq 0$, define three observables in the same positive-time Wilson algebra:

$$F_i^\varepsilon = 1 + \sqrt{\varepsilon}\, b_i X + \varepsilon c_i Y, \qquad i = 1, 2, 3. \tag{28}$$

The square root appears only at the observable level. The ρ parity in Lemma 3.2 removes half-integer powers from the Gram matrix.

Set

$$\sigma = \langle (\Theta X) X \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa}, \qquad \tau = \langle (\Theta Y) Y \rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa}. \tag{29}$$

By Proposition 3.1,

$$0 \leq \sigma \leq 1, \qquad 0 \leq \tau \leq 4. \tag{30}$$

The upper bounds follow from $|X| \leq 1$ and $|Y| \leq 2$.

Proposition 4.1 (Exact reflected Gram block)**.** *The reflected Gram matrix*

$$N_\varepsilon(i,j) = \left\langle (\Theta F_i^\varepsilon)^* F_j^\varepsilon \right\rangle_{\Lambda,\kappa} \tag{31}$$

is exactly

$$N_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^T + \varepsilon\sigma b b^T + \varepsilon^2 \tau c c^T. \tag{32}$$

In particular, $N_\varepsilon \succeq 0$ for every $\varepsilon \geq 0$.

Proof. Expanding (31), the one-point terms vanish by (25). The order-$\varepsilon^{3/2}$ mixed terms vanish by (26). The remaining terms are precisely those in (32); there are no higher terms because (28) is polynomial of degree one in $\sqrt{\varepsilon}X$ and degree one in εY. Positivity also follows directly from

$$v^T N_\varepsilon v = |\mathbf{1}^T v|^2 + \varepsilon\sigma |b^T v|^2 + \varepsilon^2 \tau |c^T v|^2.$$

□

4.2 Same-theory correlation normalization

The diagonal entries of (32) are

$$N_{11} = N_{22} = 1 + \varepsilon\sigma, \qquad N_{33} = 1 + \varepsilon^2\tau. \tag{33}$$

Define

$$D_\varepsilon = \operatorname{diag}\left((1+\varepsilon\sigma)^{-1/2}, (1+\varepsilon\sigma)^{-1/2}, (1+\varepsilon^2\tau)^{-1/2} \right) \tag{34}$$

and normalized observables

$$\widetilde{F}_i^\varepsilon = (D_\varepsilon)_{ii} F_i^\varepsilon. \tag{35}$$

Their reflected Gram matrix is

$$q_\varepsilon = D_\varepsilon N_\varepsilon D_\varepsilon, \qquad (q_\varepsilon)_{ij} = \frac{N_\varepsilon(i,j)}{\sqrt{N_\varepsilon(i,i) N_\varepsilon(j,j)}}. \tag{36}$$

This is an exact observable-level congruence. It is therefore positivity preserving and does not invoke an arbitrary pair-dependent quotient.

Proposition 4.2 (Exact normalized block)**.** *The normalized matrix is*

$$q_\varepsilon = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & \alpha_\varepsilon & \beta_\varepsilon \\ \alpha_\varepsilon & 1 & \beta_\varepsilon \\ \beta_\varepsilon & \beta_\varepsilon & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \tag{37}$$

where

$$\alpha_\varepsilon = \frac{1-\varepsilon\sigma}{1+\varepsilon\sigma}, \qquad \beta_\varepsilon = \frac{1}{\sqrt{(1+\varepsilon\sigma)(1+\varepsilon^2\tau)}}. \tag{38}$$

It satisfies $q_\varepsilon \succeq 0$ for every $\varepsilon \geq 0$ and

$$q_\varepsilon \longrightarrow \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^T \qquad (\varepsilon \downarrow 0). \tag{39}$$

If $\sigma > 0$ and $\tau > 0$, then $q_\varepsilon \succ 0$ for every $\varepsilon > 0$, and

$$\det q_\varepsilon = \frac{4\varepsilon^3\sigma\tau}{(1+\varepsilon\sigma)^2(1+\varepsilon^2\tau)}. \tag{40}$$

Proof. Equations (37)–(38) follow from (32) and (34). Positivity and the rank-one limit follow from the congruence (36). If $\sigma, \tau > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, the three linear functionals $\mathbf{1}^T v$, $b^T v$, and $c^T v$ separate points of $\mathbb{R}^3$, so (32) is positive definite. Direct calculation gives (40). □

5 Coefficient extraction and the finite certificate

Expanding (38) at $\varepsilon = 0$ gives

$$\alpha_\varepsilon = 1 - 2\sigma\varepsilon + 2\sigma^2\varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^3), \tag{41}$$

$$\beta_\varepsilon = 1 - \frac{\sigma}{2}\varepsilon + \left(\frac{3\sigma^2}{8} - \frac{\tau}{2}\right)\varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^3). \tag{42}$$

Thus

$$q_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^T + \varepsilon H + \varepsilon^2 K + R_\varepsilon, \tag{43}$$

with

$$H = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -2\sigma & -\sigma/2 \\ -2\sigma & 0 & -\sigma/2 \\ -\sigma/2 & -\sigma/2 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \tag{44}$$

and

$$K = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2\sigma^2 & 3\sigma^2/8 - \tau/2 \\ 2\sigma^2 & 0 & 3\sigma^2/8 - \tau/2 \\ 3\sigma^2/8 - \tau/2 & 3\sigma^2/8 - \tau/2 & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{45}$$

Proposition 5.1 (Uniform source-collision remainder)**.** *There is a numerical constant $C_* > 0$, independent of a, T, L, κ, r, s, h, such that*

$$\|R_\varepsilon\|_{\mathrm{op}} \leq C_*\varepsilon^3 \qquad (0 \leq \varepsilon \leq 1/4). \tag{46}$$

Proof. By (30), (σ, τ) lies in the compact set $[0,1] \times [0,4]$. The functions in (38) and their first three ε derivatives are continuous on

$$[0, 1/4] \times [0,1] \times [0,4].$$

Taylor's theorem therefore gives a uniform cubic entrywise remainder. A 3×3 Hermitian matrix has operator norm bounded by its maximum absolute row sum, which converts the entrywise bound into (46). Appendix B records an explicit admissible definition of C_*. □

Let

$$e = 3^{-1/2}\mathbf{1}, \qquad P = I - ee^T, \qquad u = 2^{-1/2}b, \qquad v = 6^{-1/2}z. \tag{47}$$

Then u, v form an orthonormal basis of $\mathbf{1}^\perp$.

Theorem 5.2 (Evaluated Schur–Feshbach gate)**.** *For the explicit block* (37)*, the first reduced coefficient is*

$$A = PHP = \sigma bb^T = 2\sigma uu^T. \tag{48}$$

The corrected second coefficient is

$$C = P\left(K - \frac{1}{3}Hee^TH\right)P = -\sigma^2 bb^T + \frac{\tau}{9}zz^T = -2\sigma^2 uu^T + \frac{2\tau}{3}vv^T. \tag{49}$$

Consequently:

(a) $A \succeq 0$ *on* $\mathbf{1}^\perp$*;*

(b) if $\sigma > 0$*, then* $\operatorname{Ker} A = \operatorname{span}\{z\}$ *on* $\mathbf{1}^\perp$*;*

(c) on that null sector,

$$z^TCz = 4\tau, \qquad v^TCv = \frac{2\tau}{3}; \tag{50}$$

(d) if $\sigma > 0$ *and* $\tau > 0$*, Proposition 2.3 applies with*

$$\alpha = 2\sigma, \qquad \beta = \frac{2\tau}{3}. \tag{51}$$

Proof. Because $b \perp \mathbf{1}$, the additive one-body terms introduced by diagonal normalization vanish after projection, and direct multiplication gives (48). Substituting (44) and (45) into Theorem 2.1 gives (49). Since $b \perp z$, the stated eigenvalues and null-sector values follow immediately. □

Remark 5.3 (The correction removes a concrete spurious term)**.** *For the null vector* z*,*

$$z^TPKPz = \sigma^2 + 4\tau, \tag{52}$$

$$z^T\left(\frac{1}{3}PHee^THP\right)z = \sigma^2, \tag{53}$$

$$z^TCz = 4\tau. \tag{54}$$

Thus the vacuum-direction coupling contributes exactly the σ^2 *term. In this example the uncorrected sign happens to remain nonnegative, but its value is wrong and would give an incorrect quantitative margin.*

Corollary 5.4 (Implemented finite Route A)**.** *For every fixed finite lattice* (12)*, every heat-kernel parameter* $\kappa > 0$*, and every admissible hairpin geometry* (18)–(21)*, the following items are established within one and the same regulated* $SU(2)$ *gauge theory:*

(i) an explicit gauge-invariant positive-time Wilson family;

(ii) the standard OS reflection used by the lattice theory;

(iii) an exact reflected Gram matrix;

(iv) a positivity-preserving normalization realized by rescaling those observables;

(v) an exact rank-one collision limit;

(vi) explicit H and K with a cutoff-uniform operator-norm remainder;

(vii) an evaluated first gate 2σ and corrected null-sector gate $2\tau/3$.

No proxy measure or pair-dependent counterterm is introduced.

6 Finite evaluation and reproducibility protocol

The only model-dependent numbers entering the closed-form block are the finite Haar integrals

$$\sigma = Z_{\Lambda,\kappa}^{-1} \int (\Theta X)(U) X(U) \prod_{\ell} dU_\ell \prod_{p} K_\kappa(U_p), \tag{55}$$

$$\tau = Z_{\Lambda,\kappa}^{-1} \int (\Theta Y)(U) Y(U) \prod_{\ell} dU_\ell \prod_{p} K_\kappa(U_p). \tag{56}$$

They can be evaluated by a finite character expansion, exact integration on a sufficiently small lattice, or reflection-symmetric Monte Carlo. Nonnegativity is already rigorous; numerical work is needed only to quantify strict margins at selected parameters.

A minimal computational record should report

$$(a, T, L, \kappa, r, s, h), \qquad \widehat{\sigma} \pm \delta_\sigma, \qquad \widehat{\tau} \pm \delta_\tau,$$

and should preserve the reflected pairing when estimating (55)–(56). A certified strict finite margin follows from

$$\widehat{\sigma} - \delta_\sigma > 0, \qquad \widehat{\tau} - \delta_\tau > 0. \tag{57}$$

The supplementary script `verify_three_hairpin_block.py` symbolically verifies the formulas for H, K, A, C, the determinant, and the two reduced eigenvalues, and can print the eigenvalues for numerical choices of $(\sigma, \tau, \varepsilon)$.

7 Open modules toward a geometric collar and a mass-gap programme

The source parameter ε in (28) makes the finite block collide while the three primitive loops remain geometrically fixed. This is sufficient to instantiate the matrix theorem and validate the same-theory normalization, but it is not yet the geometric collar collapse contemplated in the original programme. The remaining steps are stated here in a form that can be filled without changing the finite result.

7.1 Cutoff trajectory and geometric collision

A continuum-facing family would require sequences

$$a_k \downarrow 0, \qquad L_k a_k \longrightarrow \infty, \qquad T_k a_k \longrightarrow \infty, \qquad \kappa_k = \kappa(a_k), \tag{58}$$

with integer hairpin dimensions scaled to prescribed physical lengths, for example

$$a_k r_k \to R, \qquad a_k s_k \to S, \qquad a_k h_k \to H. \tag{59}$$

A genuine collar parameter δ would then enter through paths $\gamma_{i,k}(\delta)$ rather than through source amplitudes alone.

Requirement	Status in this paper	Location
Gauge group and regulator	$SU(2)$ heat-kernel plaquette measure on a finite four-dimensional lattice	Section 3
Reflection map and positive algebra	Link reflection $t \mapsto 1-t$ and Wilson algebra supported in $t \geq 1$	Proposition 3.1
Explicit Wilson geometry	Three closed hairpins sharing β	Section 3.2
Same-theory normalization	Normalized observables $\widetilde{F}_i^{\varepsilon}$; exact congruence	Equation (36)
Coefficient extraction	Closed-form H, K, and uniform $O(\varepsilon^3)$ remainder	Equations (44)–(46)
Finite test	$A = 2\sigma uu^T$, $C = -2\sigma^2 uu^T + (2\tau/3)vv^T$	Theorem 5.2
Strict finite margins	Conditional only on finite nondegeneracy $\sigma, \tau > 0$	Equation (51)
Continuum and mass gap	Not proved; separated into open modules	Section 7

Table 1: Implemented and open components of the concrete Route A realization.

Open module G1: geometric family. The finite construction uses a source collision, so the geometry of the three primitive hairpins is fixed while the matrix block becomes singular. A geometric collar version must instead introduce a family of lattice paths

$$\gamma_{+,k}(\delta), \qquad \gamma_{-,k}(\delta), \qquad \gamma_{0,k}(\delta)$$

on the cutoff lattice Λ_k, with lattice spacing a_k, such that the collar width is represented by an integer transverse displacement $m_k(\delta)$ satisfying $a_k m_k(\delta) \to \delta$. The base, longitudinal, and temporal scales should be chosen with

$$a_k r_k \to R, \qquad a_k s_k \to S, \qquad a_k h_k \to H,$$

and every edge of every path must remain in the positive-time algebra used by the reflection-positive lattice theory.

The essential geometric condition is not merely that the paths converge as sets. The reflected Wilson block requires a locked boundary footprint: the portions of the three paths that meet the reflection plane must agree in the sense needed to compare their reflected products, while the transverse collar sign distinguishes the $+$ and $-$ channels. A satisfactory construction would therefore give explicit edge lists, prove

$$\rho\gamma_{+,k}(\delta) = \gamma_{-,k}(\delta), \qquad \rho\gamma_{0,k}(\delta) = \gamma_{0,k}(\delta),$$

after reflection ρ, and show that the common footprint is independent of the collar sign. If this cannot be achieved with positive-time support and a stated joint limit (a_k, δ), the paper should retain the present source-collision result as the finite realization and not describe it as a geometric-collar theorem.

Open module G2: renormalized same-theory normalization. Once a geometric collar is introduced, the reflected Wilson entries will generally carry perimeter, cusp,

endpoint, and boundary-overlap factors. The normalization is legitimate only when these factors are removed inside the same reflected Gram problem. One-body factors are harmless: if N is the unnormalized block and $D_{k,\delta}$ is diagonal, then

$$N \succeq 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad D_{k,\delta} N D_{k,\delta}^{*} \succeq 0,$$

and this is realized by rescaling the observables themselves. The finite source-collision block uses exactly this kind of normalization.

The dangerous case is a pair-dependent factor B_{ij}. Entrywise division N_{ij}/B_{ij} is not automatically positivity preserving. A same-theory collar normalization must therefore prove one of two things: either the factor is actually produced by observable rescaling or block congruence, or the entrywise operation is a Schur product with a positive kernel, equivalently with a separately positive reflected Gram realization. Without such a positivity certificate, the geometric collar block would no longer be a reflected Gram matrix in the regulated Yang–Mills theory, and any subsequent Schur–Feshbach conclusion would be outside the theory being tested.

Open module G3: geometric coefficient extraction. The coefficient theorem needed for a geometric collar is the analogue of the exact source expansion, but with the geometric parameter δ replacing the artificial source amplitude. For the normalized geometric block one would need

$$q_{k,\delta} = \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^{T} + \delta H_k + \delta^2 K_k + R_{k,\delta}, \qquad \sup_k \frac{\|R_{k,\delta}\|}{\delta^2} \longrightarrow 0$$

in the declared joint regime. The matrices H_k and K_k must be obtained from the same normalized Wilson block produced by the collar construction and same-theory normalization, not imported from the source-collision model.

The practical calculation should separate three effects. First, additive one-body variations are killed by the projection P onto $\mathbf{1}^{\perp}$, so they do not determine the reduced first-order form. Second, genuine pairwise second variations enter PK_kP. Third, the rank-one direction contributes the Schur–Feshbach correction

$$n^{-1} P H_k e e^{*} H_k P,$$

which must be subtracted before reading the null-channel second-order margin. The finite calculation in this paper shows why that subtraction matters: without it the second null-channel value contains a spurious σ^2 contribution. The geometric collar calculation would be stronger only if it derives the corresponding H_k, K_k and remainder bound from actual Wilson geometry.

Open module G4: uniform nondegeneracy. Reflection positivity gives nonnegativity of reflected norms, but the finite Schur–Feshbach gate requires strict reduced margins. In the source-collision block these margins are 2σ and $2\tau/3$. In a collar family they become cutoff-dependent quantities, say σ_k and τ_k, after the renormalizations of G2 and the coefficient extraction of G3. The required statement is a lower-bound result along the chosen cutoff trajectory, for example

$$\inf_{k \geq k_0} \sigma_k > 0, \qquad \inf_{k \geq k_0} \tau_k > 0,$$

or a weaker but still nonvanishing bound sufficient for the scale at which the collar test is applied.

This is a genuinely mathematical input, not a consequence of bounded Wilson loops. Boundedness supplies upper bounds and compactness of finite-dimensional blocks; it does not prevent the reduced norms from collapsing in the continuum limit. Possible routes include a character-expansion estimate, a transfer-matrix lower bound, a symmetry argument excluding the vanishing channel, or a certified finite computation tied to a controlled cutoff regime. If the available evidence gives only $\sigma_k, \tau_k \geq 0$, the strict-margin claim must remain finite-cutoff and conditional.

7.2 Correct endpoint/null-channel bookkeeping

Let R be a real symmetric coefficient matrix in a normalized 3×3 block and let $z = (1, 1, -2)^T$. The exact identity is

$$z^T R z = R_{11} + R_{22} + 4R_{33} + 2R_{12} - 4R_{13} - 4R_{23}. \tag{60}$$

Only when the normalization enforces $R_{11} = R_{22} = R_{33} = 0$ does this reduce to the incidence weights

$$z^T R z = 2R_{12} - 4R_{13} - 4R_{23}. \tag{61}$$

The exact block (37) has unit diagonal for every ε, so every coefficient beyond the leading term has zero diagonal and (61) applies.

Suppose an endpoint calculation produces a computable approximation $\widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}}$ and a certified two-sided error

$$|R_{\mathrm{end}} - \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}}| \leq \Delta_{\mathrm{end}}. \tag{62}$$

Lemma 7.1 (Logically valid endpoint certificates)**.** *Let M_G be the finite positive margin before the endpoint correction. Under (62),*

$$M_G + \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} - \Delta_{\mathrm{end}} > 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad M_G + R_{\mathrm{end}} > 0, \tag{63}$$

$$M_G + \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} + \Delta_{\mathrm{end}} < 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad M_G + R_{\mathrm{end}} < 0. \tag{64}$$

If one has only a lower bound $R_{\mathrm{end}} \geq -U$, then $M_G - U > 0$ is a sufficient positive certificate, while $U > M_G$ is inconclusive.

Proof. Equation (62) gives

$$\widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} - \Delta_{\mathrm{end}} \leq R_{\mathrm{end}} \leq \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} + \Delta_{\mathrm{end}}.$$

Adding M_G proves both implications. A one-sided lower bound cannot certify negativity. □

A heat-kernel endpoint implementation could seek an estimator of the schematic form

$$\widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} = C_{\mathrm{col}} \sum_v \left(2\widehat{\kappa}^{12}_{4,v} - 4\widehat{\kappa}^{13}_{4,v} - 4\widehat{\kappa}^{23}_{4,v} \right) + \widehat{E}_{\mathrm{tail}}, \tag{65}$$

with a two-sided error obtained from source-derivative and tail estimates.

Open module E1: endpoint regulator derivation. The endpoint estimator must be derived from the same $SU(2)$ heat-kernel regulator and from the actual geometric paths of G1. The first step is to define endpoint boxes around the places where the reflected collars meet the common boundary footprint, then introduce local source variables and singlet projections for the fundamental representation. The color factor C_{col} and the incidence weights must come from this local group integral and the path ordering of the Wilson loops.

For a normalized 3×3 block with zero diagonal coefficient R, the null-channel identity is

$$z^T R z = 2R_{12} - 4R_{13} - 4R_{23}, \qquad z = (1, 1, -2)^T.$$

Thus an endpoint calculation may have the schematic form

$$\widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} = C_{\mathrm{col}} \sum_v \left(2\widehat{\kappa}_{4,v}^{12} - 4\widehat{\kappa}_{4,v}^{13} - 4\widehat{\kappa}_{4,v}^{23} \right) + \widehat{E}_{\mathrm{tail}},$$

but this formula is meaningful only after the endpoint boxes, cumulants, color normalization, and tail region have been derived from the regulated Wilson family. Otherwise the incidence expression is only a mnemonic for the null-channel algebra, not a result about the lattice gauge theory.

Open module E2: cumulant and tail bounds. The endpoint correction can be used in the Schur–Feshbach margin only with a two-sided error estimate. The target estimate is

$$|R_{\mathrm{end}} - \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}}| \le \Delta_{\mathrm{end}},$$

where R_{end} is the exact endpoint contribution in the same regulator. This requires bounds on the connected fourth source derivatives, the discretization error in the finite-difference estimator, and all omitted endpoint, corner, inter-box, and tail terms.

The five-point formula in Appendix C gives a deterministic fourth-derivative certificate once a uniform sixth-derivative bound is known. The missing analytic work is therefore to prove such a bound on the relevant source domain and to propagate it through the endpoint decomposition. With a two-sided estimate, the inequalities

$$M_G + \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} - \Delta_{\mathrm{end}} > 0 \quad \text{or} \quad M_G + \widehat{R}_{\mathrm{end}} + \Delta_{\mathrm{end}} < 0$$

certify, respectively, persistence or failure of the corrected finite margin. A one-sided lower bound can certify positivity when $M_G - U > 0$, but it cannot certify a negative obstruction.

7.3 From OS positivity to a spectral gap

Reflection positivity of finite blocks is necessary for OS reconstruction but does not imply a spectral gap. A mass-gap argument must additionally produce the continuum Schwinger functions, the reconstructed Hilbert space and Hamiltonian, and a uniform decay or spectral estimate in that same theory.

Open module M1: continuum reconstruction. Finite reflection positivity is only one component of the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction problem. A continuum reconstruction step would have to construct Schwinger functions on a separating Wilson algebra and verify the full set of hypotheses needed to obtain a Hilbert space, a vacuum vector, and Euclidean time translations. Besides reflection positivity, this includes the relevant Euclidean covariance, regularity, symmetry, tightness or compactness of the continuum limit, and nontriviality of the resulting theory.

The finite Route A block is useful because any proposed continuum theory must be compatible with such finite reflected Gram tests. It is not itself a continuum construction. A successful M1 result would specify the topology in which

$$a_k \to 0, \qquad L_k a_k \to \infty, \qquad T_k a_k \to \infty$$

and show how the regulated Wilson observables used here embed into the limiting observable algebra. Without that construction, the paper should speak only about finite-cutoff reflected Wilson blocks and necessary finite conditions.

Open module M2: gap estimate. After OS reconstruction, a mass-gap claim is a statement about the spectrum of the Hamiltonian H_{YM} in the reconstructed physical Hilbert space. The required estimate has the form

$$\mathrm{Spec}(H_{\mathrm{YM}}) \cap (0, \Delta) = \varnothing$$

for some $\Delta > 0$, with the vacuum sector separated from the first non-vacuum excitation created by gauge-invariant observables. Such a statement must be proved in the same continuum theory supplied by M1.

The finite Schur–Feshbach block does not by itself give this spectral estimate. Its role is more local: it supplies a controlled reflected-Gram obstruction or certificate that any proposed Euclidean construction must respect. A later gap argument would need a same-theory Euclidean decay estimate, transfer-matrix bound, or Hamiltonian lower bound that does not assume exponential clustering or spectral isolation at the outset. Any argument that uses the mass gap to justify the endpoint or collar estimates would be circular and should remain outside the claim boundary of this paper.

8 Conclusion

The finite Schur–Feshbach coefficient test has been implemented in a concrete reflection-positive lattice gauge theory rather than left as a conditional Wilson template. The construction fixes the compact simple group $SU(2)$, a four-dimensional heat-kernel plaquette action, the time reflection, three closed hairpin loops, a symmetry-adapted positive-time Wilson family, and an exact observable-level normalization. The resulting block is explicitly calculable and positive at every finite cutoff.

The main quantitative output is

$$A = 2\sigma u u^T, \qquad C = -2\sigma^2 u u^T + \frac{2\tau}{3} v v^T.$$

The first reduced margin is 2σ and the corrected null-sector margin is $2\tau/3$. The calculation also exhibits the purpose of the Schur correction: it removes the spurious σ^2 contribution from the second null-channel value.

What remains is now sharply separated. The present source collision must be replaced or supplemented by a lattice-resolved geometric collar; renormalized coefficients and strict margins must be controlled along a continuum trajectory; endpoint cumulants need two-sided, regulator-specific error estimates; and reflection positivity must be joined to continuum reconstruction and a spectral estimate. Those are open modules, not consequences of the finite block.

A Normalization algebra

Lemma A.1 (One-body normalization is a congruence)**.** *Let $N = N^*$ and let $D = \mathrm{diag}(d_1, \dots, d_n)$ be invertible. Then*

$$N \succeq 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad DND^* \succeq 0.$$

Proof. For every x, $x^*DND^*x = (D^*x)^*N(D^*x)$, and D^* is bijective. □

In particular, the correlation normalization

$$q_{ij} = \frac{N_{ij}}{\sqrt{N_{ii}N_{jj}}}$$

is a congruence whenever $N_{ii} > 0$. It is realized by the normalized observables $F_i/\sqrt{N_{ii}}$.

Lemma A.2 (An uncontrolled entrywise quotient need not preserve positivity)**.** *There are positive-semidefinite matrices N and B, with every entry of B positive, such that $N \oslash B$ is indefinite.*

Proof. Take

$$N = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1/10 \\ 1/10 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Both are positive semidefinite, whereas

$$N \oslash B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 10 \\ 10 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

has eigenvalues 11 and -9. □

Lemma A.3 (Zero-sum cancellation of additive one-body terms)**.** *For $d \in \mathbb{C}^n$, let*

$$L = \frac{1}{2}(d\mathbf{1}^* + \mathbf{1}d^*).$$

Then $PLP = 0$.

Proof. For $v, w \in \mathbf{1}^\perp$, both $\mathbf{1}^*w$ and $v^*\mathbf{1}$ vanish, so $v^*Lw = 0$. □

B Exact block algebra and uniform remainder

From (32),

$$N_\varepsilon = \begin{pmatrix} 1+\varepsilon\sigma & 1-\varepsilon\sigma & 1 \\ 1-\varepsilon\sigma & 1+\varepsilon\sigma & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & 1+\varepsilon^2\tau \end{pmatrix}.$$

Applying (34) gives (37). For a fully explicit uniform Taylor constant, define

$$f(\varepsilon,\sigma)=\frac{1-\varepsilon\sigma}{1+\varepsilon\sigma},$$
$$g(\varepsilon,\sigma,\tau)=\left((1+\varepsilon\sigma)(1+\varepsilon^2\tau)\right)^{-1/2}$$

and

$$M_*=\max_{\substack{0\le t\le 1/4\\0\le\sigma\le 1\\0\le\tau\le 4}}\max\left\{|\partial_t^3 f(t,\sigma)|,|\partial_t^3 g(t,\sigma,\tau)|\right\}. \tag{66}$$

The maximum is finite by compactness and positivity of the denominators. Taylor's theorem gives entrywise remainders at most $M_*\varepsilon^3/6$. The remainder matrix has zero diagonal and off-diagonal pattern (r_{12},r_{13},r_{13}), so its maximum row sum is at most $M_*\varepsilon^3/3$. Thus one may take

$$C_*=M_*/3 \tag{67}$$

in Proposition 5.1.

For the Schur coefficients, direct multiplication gives

$$PHP=\sigma bb^T,$$
$$P\left(K-\frac{1}{3}Hee^TH\right)P=-\sigma^2bb^T+\frac{\tau}{9}zz^T.$$

Since $b^Tb=2$, $z^Tz=6$, and $b^Tz=0$, the reduced eigenvalues are 2σ and $2\tau/3$.

The determinant can also be obtained before normalization. Since

$$\det N_\varepsilon=4\varepsilon^3\sigma\tau$$

and

$$\det D_\varepsilon^2=\frac{1}{(1+\varepsilon\sigma)^2(1+\varepsilon^2\tau)},$$

Equation (40) follows.

C Five-point fourth-derivative certificate

Lemma C.1 (Central five-point certificate)**.** *Let $f\in C^6([-2h,2h])$ and define*

$$D_hf=\frac{f(2h)-4f(h)+6f(0)-4f(-h)+f(-2h)}{h^4}. \tag{68}$$

Then

$$\left|D_hf-f^{(4)}(0)\right|\le\frac{h^2}{6}\sup_{|s|\le 2h}|f^{(6)}(s)|. \tag{69}$$

Proof. It is enough to prove the unit-mesh result and apply it to $g(u)=f(hu)$. The functional

$$L(g)=g(2)-4g(1)+6g(0)-4g(-1)+g(-2)-g^{(4)}(0)$$

annihilates polynomials of degree at most five. Peano's kernel theorem gives

$$L(g)=\int_{-2}^{2}K(t)g^{(6)}(t)\,dt,$$

where the kernel is nonnegative and has integral $1/6$. Hence

$$|L(g)| \le \frac{1}{6} \sup_{|t|\le 2} |g^{(6)}(t)|.$$

Since $g^{(4)}(0) = h^4 f^{(4)}(0)$ and $g^{(6)}(u) = h^6 f^{(6)}(hu)$, division by h^4 proves (69). □

For an endpoint source logarithm $\ell_v(s) = \log Z_v(s)$, the lemma turns a formal fourth cumulant into a finite-difference estimator. A usable certificate still requires a uniform bound on $\ell_v^{(6)}$ and a two-sided estimate of all tails, as stated in Open module E2.

D Checklist for the next manuscript revision

P1. Supply affiliation, contact information, acknowledgements, and a data/code statement.

P2. Choose at least one numerical finite lattice (T, L, κ, r, s, h) and evaluate σ and τ with certified uncertainties.

P3. Decide whether the principal next theorem concerns a source collision, a geometric collar collision, or both; keep the parameters notationally distinct.

P4. For a geometric collar, provide path diagrams at every cutoff and specify the joint order of $a \downarrow 0$ and $\delta \downarrow 0$.

P5. Derive any endpoint cumulant representation from the chosen action and path incidence; do not infer a negative obstruction from failure of a one-sided positive lower bound.

P6. Add a continuum theorem only after the required uniform estimates are proved. Keep the mass-gap claim separate from finite reflection positivity.

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